

Today we turn to our third big question. This question can be introduced by an example.

Suppose that in the year 2069 the surviving members of this Introduction to Philosophy class decided to have an Intro to Philosophy reunion, and all gathered in this room. Suppose that they decided to get a group picture taken.

Now imagine that, via some sort of time travel device, I now have that photo, and show it to you. You might ask: Am I one of those people? Which one am I?

It is very natural to assume that these questions must have determinate answers. There must be some fact of the matter about whether one of the people in the photo is you. And, if one is you, there must be some fact of the matter about which one is you.

Let's suppose that this is true: there must be a fact about whether you survive to be
in this picture, and must be a fact about which of the survivors you are.

Then we can ask a question about these facts:

**The survival
question:** What does it
take for for some
person at some other
time to be you?

To introduce our main answers to the survival question, it will be useful to think about a simple, uncontroversial example of survival.

All of you believe that you will wake up tomorrow in your bed. To put the same point another way, all of you believe that the person now sitting in your seat is the same person as — identical to — the person who will wake up in your bed tomorrow morning.

What do we mean when we say that you are identical to that person?

Here it is important to get clear at the outset on one distinction which, if not attended to, can make these questions more confusing than they have to be.

This is the distinction between **numerical** and **qualitative** identity.

To say that x and y are numerically identical is to say that they are literally the same thing — they are one, not two.

To say that x and y things are qualitatively identical is to say that they are exactly resembling — they have just the same properties.

When we say that you are identical to the person who will get out of your bed tomorrow morning, we are not of course saying that you are qualitatively identical to that person. Their hair will be messed up, and they will be wearing different clothes.

Rather, we mean that you are numerically identical to that person: there is just

one person who is today in this class, and is tomorrow morning in that bed.

But then we can ask the survival question: in virtue of what are you numerically
the same person as the person who will wake up in that bed?

But this is not the only answer to our question. It is a widely held view that we are not simply material beings, but also have immaterial souls.

If one believes in immaterial souls, then it is natural to think
that one's survival is closely linked to the continued
existence of one's immaterial soul.

This suggests an alternative theory of survival. On this view,
the person who wakes up in that bed tomorrow is you
because they are, or have, the same immaterial soul.

But these are not the only possible views here. One might also hold that you are that person not because of any physical connections, and not because of anything involving immaterial souls, but rather because of **psychological connections** between you and that person.

Which psychological connections? One popular approach focuses on memories. On this view, the thing which makes you the same person as the person who will wake up in that bed tomorrow is your shared memories.

Of course there are plenty of other psychological connections you will have to that person as well. You will have very similar beliefs and desires, and very similar personalities.

Let's call the idea that you are the same person because of
your psychological connections **psychological survival**.

It is worth pausing to think about the differences between the soul theory and the psychological theory of survival. At a first glance, they can look like the same thing. But they are not.

In ordinary language, 'soul' is sometimes used as a synonym for 'mind.' But remember that in the present context a soul is an immaterial thing which is closely connected to your identity.

You will be glad to know that we are not going to go through these seven theories one-by-one. Instead, we will look at a series of arguments and thought experiments which seem to make trouble for a number of these theories.

For example, we will look at arguments against the existence of immaterial souls. If successful, such an argument would rule out 4 of our 7 theories.

First, though, I want to look at some arguments which seem to count against the idea that survival requires sameness of material thing. That too would rule out 4 of our 7 theories.

We know that materialist theories require the survival
of some material thing. But which one?

As we saw above, it is very natural for the materialist to say that I am an organism. So, it would be natural for the materialist to say that my survival requires the survival of the human organism which I am.

Here's an example, due to Derek Parfit, which seems to make trouble for this view:

“Suppose first that I am one of a pair of identical twins, and that both my body and my twin’s brain have been fatally injured. Because of advances in neuro-surgery, it is not inevitable that these injuries will cause us both to die. We have between us one healthy brain and one healthy body. Surgeons can put these together.

If all of my brain continues both to exist and to be the brain of one living person, who is psychologically continuous with me, I continue to exist. This is true whatever happens to the rest of my body. ...”

In this example — which we will call **Brain Transplant** — your brain survives a car crash undamaged, while your body is destroyed, and your brain is transplanted into the healthy body of a passenger, whose brain was destroyed in the crash.

Parfit's view is that the person who would survive
this surgery is you. Is he right about that?

The problem is that the human organism which you were does not survive — only one of its organs does. So we appear to have a case in which I survive even though the organism with which I was associated does not. And that seems to rule out the idea that my survival requires the survival of an organism.

Does that rule out materialist theories?

Not quite. Someone who thinks that survival requires material continuity could simply say that the material thing which must survive is not the organism, but the brain. Call this **the brain view**.

This could be fit into various combination theories of survival. For example, if you think that survival requires the survival of a material thing and an immaterial soul, you could say that the relevant material thing is the brain.

The brain view is not challenged by the case of Brain Transplant. But it does have some somewhat odd consequences. For example, if you adopt the brain view of survival, it is at least somewhat tempting to adopt the view that I am a brain (rather than an organism). But then it looks like it should be true for me to say things like 'I weigh less than 5 pounds' - after all, my brain does!

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